

Seawall height in Miami

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

MIAMI · MIAMI-DADE COUNTY

6.0

ft NAVD88 (Miami River: 4 ft, built to rise 2 ft)

Miami-Dade County sets no countywide seawall elevation, so the City of Miami sets its own. On tidally influenced and waterfront properties citywide, seawalls, bulkheads, living shorelines and other shoreline protection must be built to at least 6 ft NAVD88. The Miami River and its tributaries are the exception: 4 ft NAVD88, designed so the wall can be raised at least 2 ft more through 2070. City Code Sec. 29-89(a)(4).

The detail

CITYWIDE	Minimum 6 ft NAVD88 for seawalls, bulkheads, living shorelines and other shoreline protection on all tidally influenced and waterfront properties, except those fronting the Miami River and its tributaries. Sec. 29-89(a)(4).
THE MIAMI RIVER	Minimum 4 ft NAVD88 for new walls fronting the river or its tributaries, designed and built so they can be raised incrementally by at least 2 ft through 2070. Sec. 29-89(a)(4).
THE RAISE PLAN	A permit application must be accompanied by a plan for incremental improvements through 2070, with modification details and load calculations showing the wall can be raised at least 2 ft. Sec. 29-89(a)(4).
WHEN IT APPLIES	New construction, or when substantial improvements to a property are performed. Sec. 29-89(a)(4).
THE 50% TRIGGER	A repair covering 50% or more of the wall's length, costing 50% or more of a new wall, or changing the elevation along 50% or more of its length must meet the standard for the length of the property. Sec. 29-89(a)(5).
BUILT TO HOLD WATER	Walls must be substantially impermeable, stopping water flowing through or over them while still relieving hydrostatic pressure from the land side. Sec. 29-89(a)(2).
THE VARIANCE ROUTE	An owner can ask the city manager's designee for a variance, for example an alternative construction method where an existing building stops the wall being raised, or to keep safe boat dockage at a single-family home, provided tidal water is still kept off neighbours and the

right-of-way. A denial can be appealed within 30 days to a four-director review committee. Sec. 29-89(a)(6).

THE COUNTY LAYER
STILL APPLIES

Miami-Dade RER-DERM permitting under Chapter 24 runs on top of the city permit, whatever the elevation.

Where this comes from: City of Miami Code Ch. 29, Art. III, Sec. 29-89(a)(2), (4)-(6) (Ord. No. 13980, 3-25-21; Municode Supp. 24 Upd. 1); Miami-Dade County Code Ch. 24 (RER-DERM permitting)

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.